



Cockfield became a convert to the idea of a “single market,” which would guarantee the free movement of goods, capital, services, and labor (the “four freedoms”) between member states. His white paper on the subject, which was well received by the other EC states, led to the Single European Act of 1986. This would create a single market in 1993, and also gave the European Parliament greater legislative powers in order to achieve this.

Meanwhile, a move to pick up the failed dream of a European political community, first suggested in 1952, had gained support in the European Parliament. In 1984, under the Spinelli Plan, drafted mainly by Italian political theorist Altiero Spinelli, the Parliament resolved to proceed from economic union to full political union. As negotiations continued, other dramatic events unfolded: the Berlin Wall fell in 1989, the USSR collapsed, and East and West Germany were unified. So it was in a buoyant mood that the 12 member states of the EC met at Maastricht in the Netherlands in December 1991 to draft a new treaty.

French newspaper *Libération* ran a hesitant-looking headline announcing the marginal result of the referendum on the Maastricht Treaty in 1992. The result became known as the “petit oui.”

European Union

One key formal objective of the Maastricht Treaty was the adoption of a universal currency. Economic and monetary union (EMU) was intended to promote the gradual convergence of member states’ economies. But before the treaty could be ratified, the law in France, Denmark, and Ireland required it to be put to a referendum. In Ireland, it was approved by a large majority, but in France, the majority in favor was tiny. In Denmark, it was rejected by an equally small margin. Only after four opt-outs for Denmark were negotiated did another referendum give its approval.

The Maastricht Treaty was signed in February 1992, and in November 1993, the EC became the EU. It inherited the institutions of its predecessor: the Commission, the Council, the Parliament, and the ECJ, which was renamed the Court

of Justice in 2009, while its lower court, formerly the Court of First Instance, was renamed the General Court. Combined, they are known as the Court of Justice of the European Union. The Commission develops overall policy and strategy and proposes new laws, while the Council of the EU—made up of ministers from each member state—coordinates policies. Together, the Council and the Parliament—which is directly elected by the public—agree and adopt new EU legislation.

Maastricht was a logical step in the 40-year process of convergence, but achieving it had not been easy. The tensions that flared between EU states in the 21st century over economic and migrant crises tested the hopes of federalist politicians. They could no longer assume that ordinary people shared their dream of progressive integration. ■

The European Court of Justice is based in Luxembourg City. Although the Court has 27 judges, one from each EU member state, cases are usually heard by panels of 3, 5, or 15.

